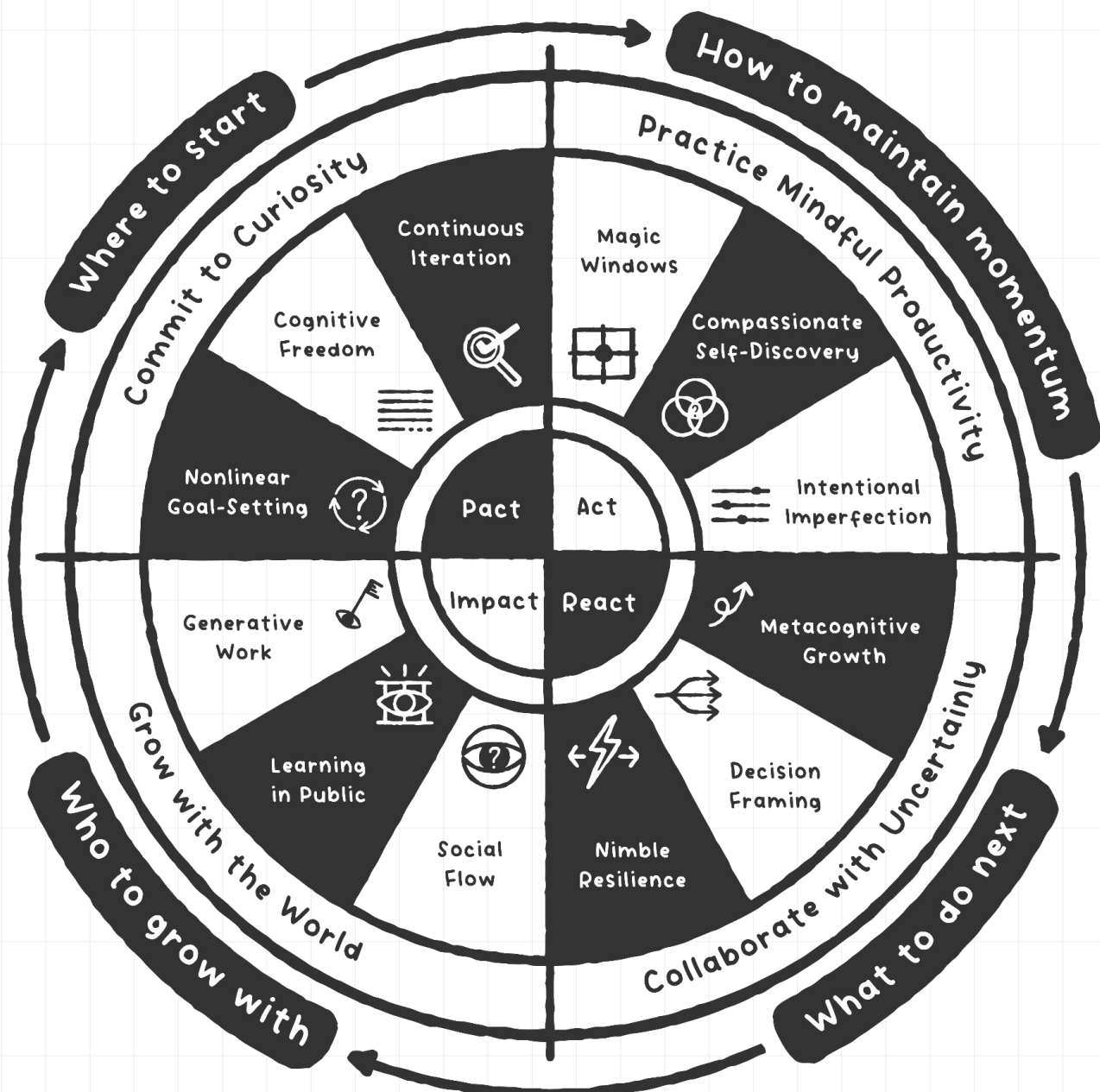


Experimentalist Toolkit

This is a quick-access reference guide for approaching any challenge with curiosity and finding success without a road map. In true scientific fashion, ask yourself how each tool can apply to your life and feel free to tailor them to fit your specific situation.

Just start by selecting the question that best describes your current situation and go to the corresponding quadrant in the toolkit. The symbol will guide you to the relevant tool on the next page.

- **Where** can I start?
- **How** can I maintain momentum?
- **What** can I do next?
- **Who** can I keep growing with?



Pact: Commit to Curiosity

(where can I start?)

Adopt an experimental mindset with the *Three Mental Shifts* (p. 37)Challenge cognitive scripts with *Field Notes* (p. 50)Design small iterative experiments with a *Pact* (p. 57)**Act: Practice Mindful Productivity**

(how can I maintain momentum?)

Open magic windows with a *Kairos Ritual* (p. 92)Listen to procrastination with the *Triple Check* (p. 106)Leverage imperfection with the *Ambition Dials* (p. 124)**React: Collaborate with Uncertainty**

(what can I do next?)

Create metacognitive growth loops with *Plus Minus Next* (p. 135)Broaden the decision frame with the *Steering Sheet* (p. 159)Dance with disruption with the *Two-Step Reset* (p. 165)**Impact: Grow with the World**

(who can I keep growing with?)

Unlock social flow with a *Curiosity Circle* (p. 186)Learn in public with the *Public Pillars* (p. 197)Do generative work with the *Five Keys* (p. 222)

List of Tools in the Experimentalist Toolkit

Tool	Helps with...
1. Three Mental Shifts	Nonlinear Goal-Setting: Adopting an experimental mindset
2. Field Notes	Cognitive Freedom: Challenging cognitive scripts
3. Pact	Continuous Iteration: Designing small iterative experiments
4. Kairos Ritual	Magic Windows: Deepening sense of time
5. Triple Check	Compassionate Self-discovery: Listening to procrastination
6. Ambition Dials	Intentional Imperfection: Practicing strategic mediocrity
7. Plus Minus Next	Metacognitive Growth: Creating growth loops
8. Steering Sheet	Decision Framing: Broadening the decision frame
9. Two-Step Reset	Nimble Resilience: Dancing with disruption
10. Curiosity Circle	Social Flow: Unlocking collective focus and creativity
11. Public Pillars	Learning in Public: Stepping into the public arena
12. Five Keys	Generative Work: Letting go of legacy

3 Key Tools to Get Started

The Experimentalist Toolkit is designed to be flexible. You don't have to use all the tools, all the time. That being said, here are the three most important tools to design, run, and analyze any experiment: the Pact, Plus Minus Next, and the Steering Sheet.

Step 1: Make a pact with yourself *(Chapters 1, 2, 3)*

Experimentation always starts with observation. Before jumping into action, take a step back and study your behaviors and cognitive scripts.

It requires treating your life just like an anthropologist studying a fascinating culture, taking field notes without any judgement.

How do you spend your time? What do you care about? What/who gives you energy, and what/who drains your energy? Once you know how things are, you can start imagining how things could be and formulate a hypothesis.

Maybe you'd enjoy a different approach, maybe you'd benefit from studying a specific topic or trying a new tool, maybe you'd be more creative by changing your work schedule...

Once you've picked an interesting hypothesis to explore, formulate your pact using this format:

I will [action] for [duration]

This mini protocol helps you commit to repeated trials, which is essential for noticing patterns and drawing conclusions. For example:

- "I will write one short reflection each morning for two weeks."
- "I will reach out to an entrepreneur I admire every Monday for a month."
- "I will meditate for ten minutes every day for ten days."
- "I will write a weekly newsletter every Thursday for six weeks."
- "I will try a new plant-based recipe every week for two months."

To reinforce your commitment, you might want to make your pact public by sharing it with a friend or on social media. Then, just do it! The key is not to get to a specific destination, but to learn from the process.

Step 2: Reflect on your progress (Chapter 7)

Experimentation without analysis is just activity; the real magic happens when trial and error form a growth loop. This is where metacognition – thinking about your own thinking – comes into play.

+	–	→

Plus Minus Next is a simple metacognitive tool you can use to analyse your progress:

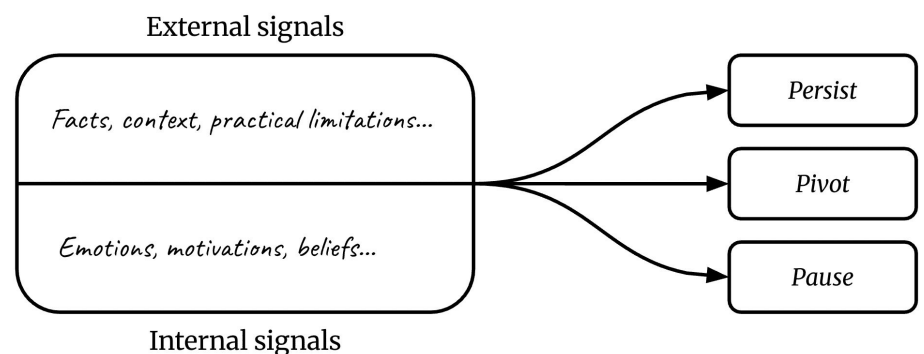
- **Plus:** What went well? What did you enjoy?
- **Minus:** What didn't work? What felt off?
- **Next:** What small tweak can you make based on what you've learned?

Depending on the format of your pact, you can use it daily, weekly, or monthly. This structured check-in prevents stagnation so you keep adapting, helping you refine your approach and iterate over time.

Step 3: Decide what's next (Chapter 8)

Once the duration of your pact is complete and you're done collecting the data, you need to decide whether you want to keep going, change your approach, or stop for now. The Steering Sheet will help you decide what to do with what you've learned.

After you've considered both the internal and external signals of success, you can choose one of those three options for your next cycle of experimentation:



- **Persist:** If your experiment is working and bringing value, just keep going as is.
- **Pivot:** If you feel like your experiment holds potential but something feels off or you're not quite happy with the results, adjust your approach.
- **Pause:** If the experiment isn't serving you, set it aside for now. Save your notes so you have them handy if you decide to give it another try in the future.

By starting with observation, committing to curiosity, and pairing action with reflection, you can transform uncertainty into a playground for growth. So, what's your first tiny experiment going to be?

Where to start

Pact: Commit to Curiosity

The first phase of the cycle is your entry point into an experimental life, breaking free from rigid thinking, linear goals, and cognitive scripts to embrace uncertainty through systematic curiosity.

CHAPTER 1

Nonlinear Goal-Setting: Transform your relationship with uncertainty through three mental shifts: (1) shifting from an anxious, automatic response to uncertainty to an autonomous one of curiosity and exploration; (2) replacing the “ladder” mental model of predetermined progress with a “loop” model of iterative learning; and (3) focusing on your output rather than the outcome. These shifts create the psychological foundation for all your experiments.



CHAPTER 2

Cognitive Freedom: Practice self-anthropology by observing your life like an anthropologist. This approach to self-discovery involves recording honest, non-judgemental observations about your daily life with timestamps. By collecting data points about your energy levels, insights, moods, and encounters throughout the day, you will build a treasure trove of information about what truly interests you outside of the shackles of cognitive scripts. These observations become the raw material for identifying patterns and formulating hypotheses worth testing.



CHAPTER 3

Continuous Iteration: The fundamental building block of personal experimentation, a pact is a simple commitment to a repeatable action over a predetermined period. Following the format “I will [action] for [duration],” a pact is like a mini-protocol for personal experimentation. A pact is purposeful, actionable, continuous, and trackable. This simple structure provides the momentum to get started and learn through iteration.



How to maintain momentum

Act: Practice Mindful Productivity

The second phase of the experimental cycle is about data collection—how you implement your experiments with intention and awareness. Instead of falling into toxic productivity or procrastination cycles, mindful productivity helps you can maintain momentum even when facing inevitable obstacles.

CHAPTER 4

Magic Windows: Your magic windows are periods of peak creativity and focus. Kairos rituals are actions that help you open magic windows at will by quickly reconnecting you to the present moment, shifting from Chronos (quantitative time) to Kairos (qualitative time). Whether through movement, breathing, or simple sensory experiences, a Kairos ritual opens your magic windows becomes your anchor for entering states of flow when you need them most.



CHAPTER 5

Compassionate Self-Discovery: When you experience procrastination, the Triple Check can help identify if the resistance is coming from your head (rational concerns), heart (emotional blocks), or hand (practical limitations). Rather than fighting procrastination with willpower, the Triple Check treats it as valuable information that can guide adjustments to your approach. This compassionate self-discovery process often reveals deeper insights about your needs and beliefs.



CHAPTER 6

Intentional Imperfection: Adjusting your ambition dials can help you embrace intentional imperfection by explicitly choosing which areas of your life deserve excellence right now and which can temporarily be good enough. By adjusting these dials consciously, you will avoid burnout while still maintaining momentum. Start by identifying your perfectionist patterns, challenge any unrealistic targets, and always choose progress over perfection.



What to do next

React: Collaborate with Uncertainty

The third phase is about embracing the unexpected results and disruptions that inevitably arise during your experiments, listen to internal and external feedback, and adapting accordingly. By collaborating with uncertainty rather than fighting it, you transform the unknown into a fertile soil for growth.

Metacognitive Growth: Metacognition is the ability to think about thinking; to observe your own thoughts. By regularly documenting your insights, you will create growth loops that compound your learning over time. Plus Minus Next is a simple metacognitive tool based on three columns: what went well, what didn't go well, and what you will focus on next. It works because it's fast, flexible, and future-focused—making metacognition an integral part of your experimental process rather than an afterthought.

Decision Framing: When deciding whether to persist, pause, or pivot with your experiments, a steering sheet provides a simple decision-making framework to help you consider both external signals (facts, context, practical limitations) and internal signals (emotions, motivations, mental states). By broadening your decision frame to include all relevant factors, it prevents helps you navigate your next steps in alignment with your deeper values and curiosity.

Nimble Resilience: The Two-Step Reset tool provides a structured approach for navigating disruptions without sacrificing your mental health. The first step involves processing the subjective experience through affective labeling—naming your emotions without judgment. The second step addresses objective consequences through mapping potential repercussions and deciding which require action. This dual process helps you transform disruptions from threats into opportunities for growth and self-discovery.

BONUS CHAPTER

Mind Gardening: In the age of algorithmic anxiety, scrolling through social media dulls our ability to think creatively. Treat your intellectual life as a garden. Actively plant seeds of inspiration (curate), link branches of knowledge (connect), and harvest new insights (create).

Who to grow with

Impact: Grow with the World

The fourth and last phase of the experimental cycle expands your focus beyond personal growth to consider how your experiments can contribute to a larger community by sharing your journey and learning with others. This phase transforms experiments from solitary pursuits into collaborative adventures that benefit both you and the world.

Social Flow: Whether you join existing communities as an apprentice, contribute as an artisan, or build your own as an architect, collective curiosity can help unlock social flow—a powerful state of collaborative focus and creativity. Embracing a spirit of experimentation, you can start small by creating a curiosity circle to gather people around shared interests rather than expertise.



Learning in Public: By sharing your work-in-progress rather than only polished results, you invite valuable feedback, clarify your thinking, learn faster, and build meaningful connections. Learning in public accelerates growth through three pillars: making a public pledge, choosing a platform, and documenting your practice. This radical transparency contributes value to others while naturally attracting collaborators and opportunities aligned with your path.



Generative Work: A generative career path focuses on present impact rather than future legacy. The Five Keys include: doing the work first (creating proof of work before seeking permission), growing lateral roots (developing cross-disciplinary skills), prioritizing impact over image (focusing on contribution rather than personal brand), closing the loop (consistently completing and publicly reflecting on projects), and playing along the way (maintaining curiosity and joy throughout the journey).



Order your copy of the book at: tinyexperiments.org

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